because the unpredictable nature of events as they unfold, perhaps in the immediate future, perhaps due to a random discovery in the archives many decades hence, may yet deliver us another ‘turn’ in the unravelling of this story which might still give cause to startle us all.

Or it might not, and as in what befalls many unexplained twists and turns in the script of our times, we may learn to become inured to the tug of an uncomfortable and persistent memory of things and people that went amiss. Like the ‘out-takes’ in footage that never quite made it into a film, about which we can say that we have a memory of being present as witnesses at the shooting, but little or no recall of ever having seen them on screen, like papers, documents, transcripts, bodies and memories that turn to dust and are scattered, the history of the attack on the Parliament of India too will in all likelihood become a hazy recollection with only the words and images of ‘terrorists’ and ‘martyrs’ and ‘threat to national security’ thrown up in bold relief, and with all else obscured within a labyrinth of shadows.

Some people call this forgetting, others call it history. The history of the Republic of India could fill an archive of lost memories. Perhaps there needs to be, somewhere near India Gate, not far from the present ‘National Archives’ and the Parliament, a site earmarked for a building to house a ‘National Archive of Forgetting’. A building—part Lutyens, part Le Corbusier, part Raj Rewal, part Kafka and part Borges—that in its architectural imagination would do true justice to the delicate combination of pomp, paranoia and amnesia that buttresses the foundations of the republic.

While there may be widespread relief in the knowledge that S.A.R. Geelani and Afsan Guru are now acquitted (if not unconditionally exonerated) by the judicial apparatus, the turn of events does not give anyone any cause for celebration. Neither the Delhi Police and the prosecution, who have seen their arguments fall like so many dead birds from the judicial sky. Those who have stood by Geelani and sought to defend him can breathe easier, and pause at the end of the maelstrom that has occupied their sleeping and waking hours, but there is little cause to rejoice. The court has maintained that there is a ‘needle of suspicion’ even as it has not been able to show any evidence to substantiate this charge. We need to ask how this ‘needle of suspicion’ got created, and why it continues to persist, quivering in the minds of the judges even as they comb swathes of missing and faulty and forged evidence. As Geelani’ himself said in a press conference immediately after the pronouncement of the verdict, ‘the acquittal of an innocent man is not an